



Sex, Marx and SMS

The suicide of a senior CPI(M) member in Tamil Nadu brings in focus the way the party micro-manages its comrades' private lives, even hounding them to death

By Shafi Rahman and Mahalingam Ponnusamy in Chennai

Wulliyanallur Ragavachariar Varadarajan had everything it takes to be a true Communist hero. Born into a middle class Brahmin family in the former North Arcot district of Tamil Nadu, he was a good orator, multilingual, fluent in his native Tamil, Hindi and English, an icon of the trade union movement, a Dalit ac-

tivist and a member of the CPI(M)'s second highest policy-making body, the Central Committee. At 64, he was young by the standards of his geriatric colleagues. But on February 11, shortly after the party's Central Committee met in Kolkata, Varadarajan sat down to scribble a suicide note and then left his home in Chennai. On February 21, a body was fished out of Porur Lake near Chennai which the police later confirmed to be Varadarajan's.

His death brings in focus the perverted ways of the CPI(M) in sneaking into people's private lives and even hounding them to death. When the party's Central Committee met early this month at Alimuddin Street in Kolkata, General Secretary Prakash Karat lip-synched Soviet-era boss Stalin and read out the judgement on the veteran trade unionist: "Varadarajan has been found engaging in conduct unbecoming of a Communist." Minutes later, the party